



BHASKAR PAUL

DEEPAK PAREKH

63, BANKER (21)

HOUSE MASTER

BECAUSE HDFC Group is one of the most profitable financial powerhouses in India, having grown 30 per cent last year, with non-performing assets at half the industry level, and despite rising interest rates. Because even before the group's life insurance division taps the capital market next year, analysts have given it a valuation of Rs 24,000 crore. Because he was top of the government's wish list when it came to heading the high-level taskforce on affordable housing for all. Because his opinion carries weight in the government's Investment Commission.

DIET SECRET: Eat everything and anything.

IS PARTICULAR ABOUT: Always being accessible to young people who come to him for academic or business advice.

NEW ACQUISITION: Personally, granddaughter Amaya. Professionally, Centurion Bank.

BIG DISCOVERY: That he has to retire this year.

HOBBY: Bridge, cricket.

AMITABH BACHCHAN

65, ACTOR (4)

THE TEFLON MAN

BECAUSE the ruling party makes a special effort to ignore him, whether at the National Awards or the Goa International Film Festival. Because he is a one-man life jacket for a party that until recently controlled Uttar Pradesh. Because whether it is a wedding or a funeral, Indians cannot have enough of his ideal happy Family No. 1. Because every ad filmmaker wants to make his first film with him. Because only he could have walked away from the wreckage of *Ram Gopal Varma ki Aag* with his aura intact. Because no one knows better than him that the troughs of modern celebritydom are as deep as its peaks are high. Because by romancing women decades younger than him, he has spawned an entire stay-young industry for older people. Because he may be bruised but he is still a heritage monument.

SMART GUY MOVE: He has set up a high school named after his daughter-in-law at the farmland he was said to have illegally bought.

BIG LOSS: His mother Teji Bachchan. A black

and white remembrance card, sent to all those who condoled her death, shows how much.

CURRENT PASSION: Finessing the details of the Bachchans' August world tour.

BANDEEP SINGH

